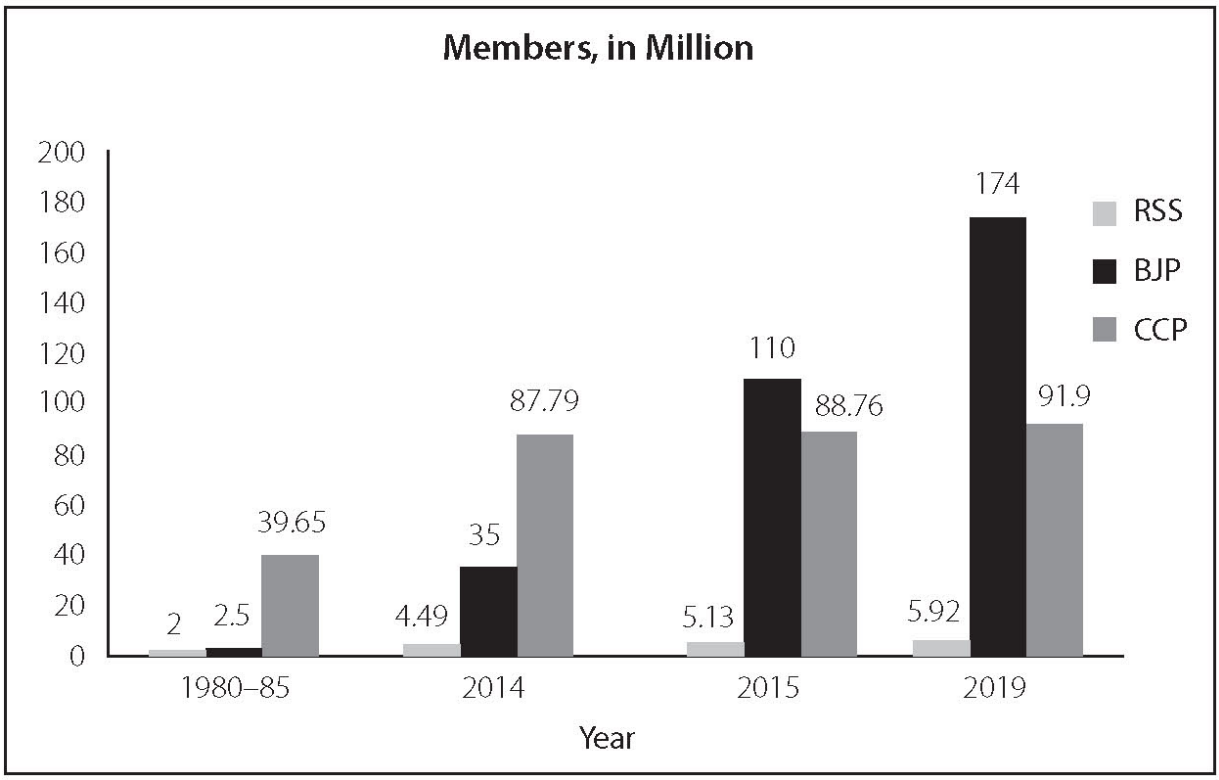


Source: RSS Annual Reports, CCP Organisation Department, BJP, Multiple Media Sources[14]

Put plainly, the BJP grew its membership almost five-fold between 2014 and 2019, during Modi's first government and under Amit Shah's presidency. India's ruling party, in 2019, was claiming membership numbers that were almost twice the size of the CCP.

This does need to be qualified. The BJP has not only been the party in office at the federal level since 2014, it had held power in as many as seventeen of India's twenty-eight states by the end of 2019. It is not uncommon for membership numbers of ruling parties to increase for instrumental reasons. Equally, the RSS has often been significant in states where the party has not been in power until recently, such as Maharashtra, where the BJP was in power only in 1995–1999 and 2014–2019, even while it remained home to the RSS headquarters in Nagpur.

Even if we assume that one-third of the members claimed by the BJP in 2019 were 'transient'—those attracted to the ruling dispensation and in danger of leaving if the party lost power—the